BIOLOGICAL/PHYSICAL FALSE BELIEF #2 · CHRONIC ILLNESS

“I am nothing but my illness.”

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Where it often comes from

Appointments, symptoms, medication schedules, and other people’s questions can make illness the center of life. The label can replace the name. Over time, we may stop seeing ourselves as a person who happens to be sick and start seeing a patient, a case, or a problem.

What Scripture teaches

God knew you before any diagnosis: “You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother’s womb” (Psalm 139:13). Jesus said, “Even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows.” Paul says, “Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation.” Your identity is a child of God, loved, gifted, and called. Illness is something you have, not who you are.

> *“For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother’s womb”* (Psalm 139:13).

Also see

> “And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows” (Luke 12:7).

> “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” (2 Corinthians 5:17).

> “For we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life” (Ephesians 2:10).

> “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well” (Psalm 139:14).

Common self-statements

- I am just a patient.
- My illness defines me.
- Nothing else about me matters.
- People only see my condition.
- I am my diagnosis.
- I have no identity apart from this.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either well or defined by illness.
- Fortune telling: Predicting I will never be more than a patient.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling consumed and concluding that I am the illness.
- Labeling: Calling myself my diagnosis.

Challenging questions

- What did I enjoy and value before this illness?

- What parts of me are not touched by it?
- Who sees me as more than my diagnosis?
- What does God call me?
- What small activity can remind me who I am?
- How could I introduce myself without mentioning my illness?

Truth summary

> I am a person loved by God, with gifts, relationships, and purpose. My illness is part of my story, not the whole of it.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Sickness
- God, Creator
- Love, By God
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Weak/Tired

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I am nothing but my illness"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I am nothing but my illness." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did I enjoy and value before this illness?
- ☐ What parts of me are not touched by it?
- ☐ Who sees me as more than my diagnosis?
- ☐ What does God call me?
- ☐ What small activity can remind me who I am?
- ☐ How could I introduce myself without mentioning my illness?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am known by God by name.
- ☐ I am worth more than many sparrows.
- ☐ I am a new creation in Christ.
- ☐ I was made for good works.
- ☐ I am more than my diagnosis.
- ☐ My story is larger than this.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 139:13
  "For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb."
- ☐ Luke 12:7
  "And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 5:17
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] More than my diagnosis: Each week, note one thing you did or enjoyed that was not about illness.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 139:13 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am a child of God, not a diagnosis.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] List who you are. Write ten things true of you apart from illness.
- [ ] Do one thing you love. Choose an activity within your abilities.
- [ ] Tell someone. Share a part of you that is not about health.
- [ ] Memorize Luke 12:7. Say it when the label feels too big.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I am nothing but my illness": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	More than my diagnosis
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I am nothing but my illness.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You know me by name, not by a diagnosis. Remind me who I am in You, and help me enjoy what remains of me and my life. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.